

Chapter 15

Use and Creation of Social Media by Travellers

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1. Introduction

In 2006, TIME magazine assigned the title of Person of the Year to “You”, the modern online users who create and control information. Since then, these online users have been increasingly empowered by the emergence of a plethora of social media applications that support the creation and use of social media. The growing availability and popularity of these applications have transformed the way people communicate, make decisions, socialize, learn, entertain themselves, interact with each other, or even do their shopping (Constantinides and Fountain 2008). Not surprisingly, these impacts can also be identified with relation to consumer behaviour in travel and tourism.

Given the experiential nature of tourism, the information created by other travellers is even more important and influential in travellers’ information search and decision making processes. Growing numbers of travellers search and consume travel information created by other travellers for their travel planning and share their experience after returning from trips (Cox, Burgess, Sellitto and Buultjens 2009). According to a recent report, more than 80 per cent of leisure travel buyers were influenced by various types of user-generated contents including videos, reviews and blogs in the context of travel purchase decisions (PhoCusWright 2008). Similarly, other studies found that 40 per cent of online travel planners consider user-generated contents in their travel decision (JupiterResearch 2008) and 23 per cent of US Internet

users' vacation decisions are influenced by social media (Ad-ology Research 2009). In addition, a study by Brown (2009) found that more than one-quarter of US Internet users who followed brands on social networks followed a travel brand. Further, more than half of travel marketers indicated that they continue to invest heavily in social media despite the economic downturn (eMarketer 2009a). Clearly, social media have taken on an important role in shaping the attitudes and behaviours of travel consumers as well as travel and tourism marketers.

Recognizing the growing importance of social media, recent academic tourism publications increasingly discuss social media trends in tourism (e.g. Pan, MacLaurin and Crotts 2007, Sigala 2008, O'Connor 2008, Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier 2008, Cox et al. 2009, Xiang and Gretzel 2009, Yoo and Gretzel 2010, Volo 2010). While current findings provide some important insights for understanding social media in tourism, there is still a lack of studies that have empirically investigated how social media are used and created by travellers. Further, the rapid changes in the social media field create a need for more theoretically grounded research that can describe and explain new consumer behaviours beyond a specific social media application. Consequently, this chapter seeks to provide an examination of online social media use and creation by travellers that focuses on main issues related to creation and use. For that purpose, this chapter will first review relevant studies that examined social media use and creation. Then, based on the findings of two national surveys on travellers' social media use conducted in the United States in 2008 and 2010, this chapter will provide empirical findings addressing the following issues: 1) patterns of use; 2) impacts on trip planning and decision-making; and, 3) characteristics of travel-related social media users and creators. Finally, this chapter will conclude with a discussion of the opportunities and challenges that exist for travel practitioners as well as

researchers given the investigated characteristics and behaviours of travel-related social media users and content creators.

2. Theoretical Foundations

Social Media Foundations

Web 2.0 is considered to be a new version of the World Wide Web that changed the ways end-users engage with the Web (Kaplan and Haenlein 2010, O'Reilly 2005). The fundamental principle of Web 2.0 is that online users add value by generating contents through various application tools including blogs, wikis and social networks (Chaffey et al. 2009, Parise and Guinan, 2008, O'Reilly 2005). While many use the terms social media and Web 2.0 interchangeably, these concepts are closely related but different. Web 2.0 is considered as the platform for the evolution of social media. Social media refer to “a group of Internet-based applications that build on the ideological and technological foundations of Web 2.0, and that allow the creation and exchange of User-Generated Content” (Kaplan and Haenlein 2010: 61). This includes a number of different applications which allow online users to “post”, “tag”, “digg”, or “blog”, and so forth, on the Internet (Xiang and Gretzel 2009).

Various forms of social media currently exist and new sites appear online every day. According to Constantinides and Fountain (2008), there are five main categories of social media, which include blogs, social networks, content communities, forums/bulletin boards and content aggregators. Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) classified social media into six types based on the degree of social presence/media richness and the degree of self presentation/disclosure. Their classification of social media includes blogs, social networking sites (e.g., Facebook), virtual social worlds (e.g., Second Life), collaborative projects (e.g., wikipedia),

content communities (e.g., You Tube) and virtual game worlds (e.g., World of Warcraft).

Using these various types of social media, a growing number of online users becomes increasingly involved in various online activities. According to Shao (2009), online individuals deal with social media in three ways: consuming, participating and producing contents online. The findings of previous studies (Nonnecke and Preece 2001, Shao 2009, Tedjamulia et al. 2005, Van Dijck 2009) indicated that a majority of online users just consumes the contents posted by others. Some engage in user-to-user interactions and user-to-content interactions, such as ranking the content and posting comments, but do not create online contents. Only a small number of users creates online contents including text, images, audio and video. These studies suggested that the three activities may represent a path of gradual involvement with social media. People begin their relationship with social media as consumers or lurkers but gradually evolve to the next stage of participating and then finally come to produce CGM contents. Similarly, Forrester (2007) developed “Social Technographics”, which categorized social computing behaviours into a ladder with six levels of participation. The study found that 13 per cent of US online adults are “Creators” who publish contents to their social media sites while 19 per cent are “Critics” who comment on social media sites and also post ratings and reviews. Some users are “Collectors” (15%) who use RSS or tag web pages or “Joiners” (19%) who simply join and use social networking sites. A good percentage of online users are found to be “Spectators” (33%) who consume social media contents generated by other peers or “Inactives” (52%) who are not involved in any of these activities.

Social Media in Tourism

In tourism, Web 2.0 also referred to as “Travel 2.0” describes a new interactive approach to travel technologies (PhoCusWright 2006). Travel 2.0 applications include content syndication, mash-ups, AJAX, tagging, wikis, web forums/message boards, customer ratings systems, virtual worlds, podcasting, blogs and online videos (Schmallegger and Carson 2008). Among these various types of social media used by travellers, travel blogs have received a lot of research attention (Braun-LaTour, Grinley and Loftus 2006, Douglas and Mills 2006, Karlsson 2006, Lee, Yoo and Gretzel 2009, Lin and Huang 2006, Mack, Blose and Pan 2008, Pan et al. 2007, Pudliner 2007, Schmallegger and Carson 2008, Thevenot 2007, Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier 2008, Volo 2010, Wenger 2008). Travel blogs were identified not just as a good platform that can communicate travel experiences outside of the narratives of tourism marketers (Pudliner 2007) but also an effective tool for promotion, product distribution, management as well as research (Schmallegger and Carson 2008, Volo 2010). The trustworthiness of blogs to travellers (Mack, Blose and Pan 2008) and the cultural differences in terms of social media use and impacts (Lee, Yoo and Gretzel 2009, Volo 2010) were also discussed. Other important forms of travel social media are online travel reviews and communities. The popularity and impacts of travel reviews have been investigated in previous studies (Gretzel and Yoo 2008, O’Connor 2008, Vermeulen and Seegers 2009, Yoo et al. 2009). Online travel communities have the longest tradition as online venues for travellers to engage in travel storytelling, to find or share information, and also to support travel planning (Arsal, Backman and Baldwin 2008, Chung and Buhalis 2008, Kim, Lee and Hiemstra 2004, Wang and Fesenmaier 2004a, Wang, Yu and Fesenmaier 2001). In addition, other multimedia forms of travel social media such as videos, photo sharing and podcasting are

increasingly used by travellers to portray their tourism experiences (Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier 2009, Xie and Liew 2008).

With these various social media applications, more and more online travel content is created by travellers and serves as an important information source for trip planners as well as tourism practitioners (Carrera et al. 2008, Gretzel et al. 2009, Litvin, Goldsmith and Pan 2008, Pan, MacLaurin and Crofts 2007, Xiang and Gretzel 2009, Yoo and Gretzel 2008a). According to a recent report by eMarketer (2010), three out of the top ten online travel information sources used by US adults were social media sites. Social media contents are extremely search engine friendly (Gretzel 2006), thus the contents are easily accessible to travellers (Xiang and Gretzel 2009). Further, recent advances in mobile technologies and rising ownerships of smart phones mean travellers can easily access social media during their travel. According to a recent report by the Pew Research Center (2010), more than half (52%) of Americans own laptops, 85 per cent own cell phones and the number of tablet computer users is rapidly growing as well. The U.S. smart phone users now amount to more than 45 million (ComScore 2010) and, importantly, the smart phone has become one of the most important devices for travellers (Charlesworth 2009). Using their mobile technologies, travellers actively access social media in the course of their travel for information searches, posting of accounts of their experiences, as well as networking. A report by Tnooz (2010) found that social networks technology is one of the most widely used technologies during travel (38% in the U.S. and 64% outside of the U.S.) It is obvious that social media provide a fertile venue for travellers to create and share their travel experiences and also take on an important role in tourist information search and decision making. Thus this suggests the needs of better

understanding on social media users and creators and what factors contribute to their social media engagement.

Users and Creators of Social Media

Online users deal with social media in a number of different ways. As discussed earlier, social media users were classified into different categories based on their social media participation (Forrester 2007, Nonnecke and Preece 2001, Shao 2009, Tedjamulia et al. 2005, Van Dijck 2009). Previous studies identified a number of different factors that influence social media involvement behaviours. Forrester research (2007) suggests that online users' social media engagements differ by their primary life motivation, the types of social media sites used and even the type of PC ownership. Trust has also been addressed as an important factor that influences social media use and creation (Nielsenwire 2009, Yoo et al. 2009). A higher level of trust leads to a higher level of social media engagement (Burgess et al. 2009, Yoo, Lee and Gretzel 2007). In addition, the personality of users has been found to be influential in determining social media behaviours (Acar and Polonsky 2007, Jeng and Teng 2008, Ross et al. 2009, Yoo and Gretzel 2010). Although the results are somewhat inconsistent, existing research suggests positive influences of openness, extraversion, agreeableness and conscientiousness on social media creation motivations and behaviours, while negative relationships were suggested for neurotic individuals. A good number of studies also indicated influences of individuals' socio-demographic characteristics such as age, gender, education and income on social media activities. For most types of social media, younger users were found to be more active users and creators (Jones and Fox 2009, Lenhart et al. 2007, Verna 2009) while US bloggers tend to be mostly 25 or older males (Technorati 2010). Male adults are more active

social media creators than female adults while females tend to dominate when users are limited to preteens, teens and college students (Verna 2009). The US social media user is found to be more likely college educated, full-time employed and dominantly white (eMarketer 2009b). Further, levels of education and income of social media users differ by type of social media. The users of LinkedIn tend to be more educated, have higher income and are more likely full-time employed while Facebook and MySpace users tend to have lower incomes and are more likely students.

In terms of travel-related social media use and creation, a number of previous studies have investigated the determinants of social media engagement behaviours. Wang and Fesenmaier (2004b) suggested that travellers engage in online travel communities for functional, social, psychological and hedonic benefits. Similarly Chung and Buhalis (2008) found that travellers get involved in virtual communities for information, social-psychological and hedonic benefits. The study by Yoo and Gretzel (2008a) found that travel review writers who contribute to TripAdvisor are mostly motivated by intrinsic motives of enjoyment, concerns for other travellers or the desire to help the company while only some are motivated by the opportunity for venting. Recent findings (Parra-Lopez et al. 2010), indicate that travellers more likely intend to use social media when they perceive greater benefits and greater altruism, availability, individual predisposition or trust. However, it was also found that costs related to the use of social media like effort, privacy concerns or difficulty to use do not significantly affect intentions to use social media. In addition, travellers' gender and income level (Yoo and Gretzel 2008a), nationality (Gretzel, Kang and Lee 2008) culture (Lee, Yoo and Gretzel 2009), membership in a generational cohort (Yoo and Gretzel 2009) and their involvement in trip planning (Yoo and Gretzel, 2008b), as well as their personality (Yoo and Gretzel, 2010) have been identified as factors

influencing travellers' social media use and creation behaviours, suggesting that travellers' personal characteristics are important factors to be taken into account when trying to understand engagement with social media. Looking specifically at travel social media creation, travel social media creators tend to be young (Yoo and Gretzel 2009), male, and have higher incomes and greater internet skills (Yoo and Gretzel, 2008c). They are also more likely frequent travellers as well as highly involved in trip planning (Yoo and Gretzel, 2008b). In addition, being part of a collectivist culture was found to increase the likelihood to produce blog contents targeting a general public, while individualistic values lead to the creation of contents that reflect personal experiences and serve the purpose of documentation and ego-enhancement (Lee et al. 2009). Further, travel photo posting was found to be a prominent activity for younger generations while boomers and seniors are not likely to post photos online (Yoo and Gretzel, 2009).

While these studies suggest a number of factors and characteristics regarding travel social media users and creators, the findings are rather fragmented since most findings are limited to certain social media types or specific individual characteristics. Further, previously identified profiles for social media users and creators should be updated given the growing popularity of social media. Thus, this chapter seeks to close this knowledge gap by providing the findings of two recent U.S. national surveys on travellers' social media engagement.

3. Methodology

Two online surveys representative of the general US population were conducted with the support of the National Laboratory for Tourism and eCommerce and the U.S. Travel Association. The first online survey was conducted in July 2008. A total of

59,186 members of a commercial online research panel residing in the United States were invited to participate in the survey. No additional incentives beyond the rewards provided by the panel company were offered. A total of 3,109 panellists responded to the survey invitation but only 2,671 indicated they were active Internet users. Further, of those Internet users, 1,682 had travelled for pleasure within 12 months prior to the study. These online travellers form the actual sample for the 2008 study.

In 2010 a similar study was conducted. This time a total of 2,046 panellists responded to the survey invitation but only 1,810 indicated they were active Internet users. Further, of those Internet users, 1,221 had travelled for pleasure within 12 months prior to the study. These online travellers form the actual sample for the 2010 study. The two samples obtained are comparable in terms of demographics, but with the 2010 sample being slightly more male and younger. Some adjustments were made to the 2010 questionnaire to reflect the emergence of new social media such as Twitter.

4. Findings

Patterns of Use

Xiang and Gretzel (2009) provide evidence that travellers are likely to find social media related sites during their online information search queries. However, it is not clear whether travellers actively seek out social media sites when planning overnight pleasure trips. The two surveys asked travellers to indicate which websites they used during their online travel planning efforts. The Results (Table 15.1) show that online travel agency and auction sites (Expedia, Travelocity, Priceline, etc.), general search engines (Google, Yahoo!, etc.) and service provider websites (airlines, hotels, rental cars, etc.) are most prominently used in online travel searches. However, pure social

media sites like blogs and communities as well as photo/video sharing sites and social networking sites are also used in the context of online travel planning. The results are pretty stable over time, except for online travel agencies and service providers losing ground in 2010.

Table 15.1

Websites Used for Planning Overnight Pleasure Trips

Website Type Used	2008 (% of online travellers)	2010 (% of online travellers)
Online Travel Agency/Auction	52.4	43.1
Search Engine	48.6	51.1
Service Provider	46.0	35.3
Tour Operator	4.8	5.2
Full Service Travel Agency	7.2	7.3
Destination	24.8	23.0
Travel-Related Blogs/Communities	8.6	5.7
Travel Price Comparison	12.1	10.8
Travel Sales/Special Websites	7.7	5.9
Photo/Video Sharing	N/A	4.6
Social Networking	N/A	8.1

When asked whether they used contents/media created by other travellers, about half of the respondents indicated that they did and this result was almost exactly the same for both years (Table 15.2). The high percentage of people stating that they use social media but lower percentages of users of pure social media sites suggests that social media embedded in travel websites such as online travel agency and destination sites are important.

Table 15.2

Use of Travel-Related Consumer-Generated Media

Did you read comments/materials posted online by other travellers in the course of planning your most recent overnight pleasure trip?	2008 (% of online travellers)	2010 (% of online travellers)
Yes	50.5	49.2

In terms of types of social media used, travel reviews are the most prominent form (Table 15.3). Photos posted by others are also frequently used as input in travel planning processes. Audio files/podcasts and tweets are only used by a minority of online travellers who use social media. The difference between 2008 and 2010 in terms of videos could be to some extent due to the significant gender influence on video use and the slightly higher male ratio in the 2010 sample.

Table 15.3

Types of Social Media Used

Type of Social Media	2008 (% of social media users)	2010 (% of social media users)
Travel Reviews	80.5	71.8
Tweets	N/A	6.9
Photos	50.6	54.9
Videos	14.2	23.9
Blogs	21.8	21.7
Comments on Blogs	23.6	25.6
Postings in Discussion Forums	22.4	21.9
Audio files/Podcasts	3.8	4.6

Analyses were also conducted to see whether specific types of social media were connected to broad overall social media use. Table 15.4 shows that of those who use social media for travel, many only use one or two types, while some use three. However, there is also a small portion of online travellers who use social media very broadly.

Table 15.4

Number of Social Media Types Used

Number of Social Media Types Used	2008 (% of social media users)	2010 (% of social media users)
1	38.8	39.3
2	29.0	23.9
3	17.3	18.0
4	8.5	9.8
5 or more	6.5	9.2

The number of social media types used was then linked to the specific forms of social media. The results (Table 15.5) show that of those who use just one type, most use travel reviews, followed by photos. Looking at when specific types reach at least 50% penetration, tweets and videos are connected only with the broadest levels of use while podcasts are still not widely used even by those who use five or more social media types for travel planning.

Table 15.5

Social Media Use Scope

Social Media Type	Number of Social Media Types Used									
	1		2		3		4		5 or more	
	2008	2010	2008	2010	2008	2010	2008	2010	2008	2010
Travel Reviews	73.0	54.7	85.1	79.1	85.6	85.5	90.2	82.2	100	95.7
Tweets	-	1.1	-	1.8	-	6.0	-	17.8	-	60.2
Photos	12.4	20.4	70.1	65.5	77.9	80.7	74.5	82.2	100	98.3
Videos	2.1	6.6	6.3	10.0	23.1	38.6	39.2	44.4	77.8	82.4
Blogs	3.9	3.3	12.1	11.8	30.8	21.7	68.6	57.8	92.6	95.7
Blog comments	3.9	8.3	11.5	13.6	42.3	31.3	68.6	60.0	94.4	89.8
Discussion forum postings	3.9	5.5	14.9	15.5	39.4	32.5	52.9	53.3	87.0	83.6
Audio/podcasts	0.9	0.0	0.0	2.7	1.0	3.6	5.9	2.2	48.1	44.4

Impact on Travel Planning

One of the most important questions to answer is whether social media actually influence travellers' decisions. Table 15.6 shows that a considerable percentage of online travellers who use social media perceives at least some impact on their decision making. The greatest impact is felt with respect to where to stay, which is not surprising given the dominance of travel reviews, which most often are written regarding hotels. However, activities and restaurant choices are also very much influenced. In general, greater impacts were perceived by the social media users in the 2010 study compared to the 2008 respondents.

Table 15.6

Influence of Social Media Use on Travel Decisions

Travel Decision	2008 (% of social media users)	2010 (% of social media users)
Where to go	57.2	68.8
How to go there	52.5	59.5
When to go	51.5	61.4
What to do	75.2	76.6
Where to stay overnight	81.0	81.8
Where to eat	68.3	76.6
Where to shop	56.2	65.1

Impacts were also measured with respect to certain travel information search behaviours. About half of those who use social media for travel planning indicated that the use changed their information search behaviours (Table 15.7). In general, these influences were even higher in 2010. The most influenced aspects of travel information search are the amount of time spent on advance planning, the number of information sources used, and the amount of print-outs taken on the trip. In all cases, social media use tended to increase these facets of travel planning.

Table 15.7

Influence of Social Media on Travel Information Search

Travel Information Search Behaviour	2008 (% of social media users)	2010 (% of social media users)
Number of destinations considered	44	45.9
Amount of time spent on advance planning	49.5	55.8
Number of information sources used	55.3	56.5
Use of ads (TV, radio, press) for travel ideas	41.5	45.9
Stops at visitor information centres	43.6	47.2
Likelihood of buying travel guidebooks/maps	45.9	48.4
Number of travel brochures ordered	45.3	48.6
Amount of print-outs taken on trips	52.2	52.1

Characteristics of Users and Creators

While half of online travellers are social media users, only about 20 per cent of online travellers have ever posted travel-related contents online (Table 15.8). When looking at social media users, the percentage increases but is still rather low, indicating that a majority of social media users solely consume contents. Thus, it is important to not only understand who uses social media but also to analyze who the content creators are.

Table 15.8

Travel-Related Social Media Creators

Have you ever posted travel related comments/materials online?	2008 (% of online travellers)	2008 (% of social media users)	2010 (% of online travellers)	2010 (% of social media users)
Yes	17.0	27.0	21.9	37.2

As far as the socio-demographic characteristics of social media users are concerned, there were no gender differences between users and non-users. However, there were significant differences in terms of age, with social media users being younger than non-users. Social media users are also less likely divorced/separated/widowed than non-users and are more likely employed full-time. No significant differences exist regarding education level and income. Social media users are also more likely Hispanic or Asian in ethnic origin than non-users.

Comparing those who create travel-related social media to those online travellers who do not, again no significant gender differences can be found but age differences do emerge with younger online travellers being more likely social media creators. In addition, social media creators are more likely single and again more likely employed full-time. Similar to social media users, no significant differences in

terms of education and income emerged. Regarding ethnic origin, social media creators are more likely Asian.

5. Summary and Discussion

Social media are not used by all online travellers for travel planning but by a substantial number of them. The findings related to usage patterns show that although new social media constantly emerge, the patterns were pretty stable from 2008 to 2010. Also, the results clearly indicate that social media used for travel planning are not equal. Some appeal to a broad group of travellers while others are only used by those who use social media extensively. Online travellers not only use social media, the information derived from them has a considerable impact on travel decisions, most notably where to stay, what to do and where to eat. Social media use also changes information search behaviours in that it leads to more time spent planning, more information sources used and more print-outs taken on the trip for at least half of the social media users. Thus, interestingly, social media use expands information search and use instead of providing efficiencies.

While many online travellers use social media for their travel planning, only a small portion actively contributes contents. From a practical point of view, it is very important to understand who these users are and even more essential to examine by whom social media contents are created. The findings show that age, marital status, employment status and ethnic origin are important drivers of both travel social media use and creation.

The findings mostly confirm what the existing literature has found: social media are important information sources for travellers and influence travel planning and decision-making. However, the results presented in this chapter suggest that while

overall social media use statistics are useful to understand global patterns, great differences exist among the various types of social media. These differences have so far not received sufficient attention. Further, the research confirmed that social media users and social media creators differ from the general population of online travellers in terms of demographic characteristics. This means that market insights derived from social media contents do not necessarily reflect general opinions.

This chapter provided an American perspective on social media use and creation in tourism. However, its general approach in terms of conceptualizing use and influence provides an overall framework that is applicable to other contexts. It showed that there are degrees in use linked to types of social media. It further illustrated that social media are not just another information source but rather fundamentally change travel planning for those who use them. At the same time, it has to be recognized that social media use has not completely replaced other forms of online travel information search but rather speaks to a certain group of travellers.

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